Interactive Awareness and *Slow Art*

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The near-universal accessibility of the visual has demanded a multitude of products, both solid and abstract, to satisfy the needs of the mass. This paper focuses on the Sundaram Tagore Gallery's *Slow Art* exhibition. It seeks to define an exhibition and its displays may present itself to this diverse range of viewers, using a case study.

There exist several publications that attempt to specify how exactly an exhibited object and its authority shapes itself to a person through nostalgia, craftsmanship, or even have such a role "foisted upon them" (Black, 2011, p. 418). However, they fail to take into account that the word 'viewer' is a misnomer – a viewer is autonomous, active, interactive.

Modes of Interaction

Visual culture, first and foremost, necessitates a space of interaction. In the first instance, viewership is a simple tautology – there must exist a thing to be viewed, and there needs to be a sentient viewer for the thing to communicate and interact with. However, this interaction is not limited to a single viewership: in fact, it *cannot* be limited to an individual. As Berger (1972) reminds us, "to look . . . is to situate oneself in relation to [an object]" (p. 8) and 'oneself' brings to the table a lifetime of sense, memory, logic, rules, and indeed, any manner of social experience. The single viewer by themself is an entry point to the mass.

The mass, in turn, is an even richer, inexhaustible wealth of experience that consists of politics, government, other forms of art, economies, culture, religion, and morality. This experience bestows upon the mass a certain power – that of contextualisation. Visual culture thus both contributes to and is a product of this contextualisation, making it a bidirectional correlate of the mass. By virtue of being part of the mass, contextualisation power is transferred to an individual, where it manifests in critical thought.

Though each individual possesses critical thought, their use of it in interaction with the visual is entirely dependent on an additional factor: the degree to which they are aware of this

power. It must be noted that, in this case, ‘awareness’ merely connotates a kind of consciousness – a lower degree of awareness is not a dispositional ignorance, nor should it facilitate a dichotomous categorization based on class, education or profession. Indeed, viewers across various time and circumstances transition from high-awareness to low-awareness perspectives and vice versa.

This degree of awareness causes a shift in how we assimilate both internal and external experiences. For visual culture, a universally dialectical phenomenon which in its primer is defined as a space that “is contested and transformed as a constantly challenging place of social interaction” (Mirzoeff, 2005, p. 6), this awareness is instrumentally significant. Moreover, as a discipline concerned with the layman’s susceptibility to the visual, it is important to be able to switch across these modes of awareness.

In the rest of this section, I attempt to describe the levels of awareness at which individuals can operate while interacting with visual culture. I must extend a cautionary note: these levels are neither absolute categories nor do they presume to encompass all types of awareness. They are merely indicators of a mode of interaction one may subscribe to, which in turn affects how the visual is seen.

At the foundation of an hierarchy of awareness is simply attending to the visual – looking but not necessarily seeing. Such an interactor, *the spectator*, is a visitor to an exhibition who indulges in sensory experiences of being surrounded by visual stimuli and selectively attends to the aesthetic. A work to them is superficial, but not material – it is abstract in its relation to them, because the only use it has is that of pleasure, or what Mirzoeff (2005) refers to as ‘the sublime’.

Further up the hierarchy of awareness is *the admirer*. This is the engaged viewer, who registers the talent or skill required to create a piece of art. They appreciate the formal parameters of a work beyond the mere experience of them. Their appreciation gives them a

cognizance of their own skills in relation to the work which are lacking in comparison to that which was *chosen* to be displayed. This perceived lack of their own skill gives the work a greater authority in the admirer's view, and thus they generously lend to all art the benefit of meaning and depth.

Beyond admiration, an aware interactor tends to reduce a work to an object. This occurs in two distinct ways, as a function of buying power. *The consumer*, who has the buying power, can contemplate possessing the work. They transition from admirer to consumer, traversing the line of spectator-owner (Berger, 1972). They imagine the work displayed in their personal spaces, and in doing so, displace the work from its current space in an exhibition. The painting is reduced to its material as a commodity, which can be packed up, transported and hung again.

On the other hand, those without such buying power assume the role of *the sceptic*. The critic or even a student of visual art often operates somewhere in between the admirer and the sceptic. They are intrinsically aware of the role of authority that has led the work's exhibition. Seeing the work in and as a context, the sceptic reduces it to a production of social, cultural, economic, political, and related forces, stripping it of any mysticism (that the admirer yet holds) and plainly viewing it as an object.

Each aforementioned mode of interaction provide unique insight into any given performance of the visual, affecting the way an individual critically thinks about an exhibition and, subsequently, how the mass contextualises.

The Case of *Slow Art*

The following section reviews an exhibition, *Slow Art: Stop, Look, and Linger*, displayed at the Sundaram Tagore Gallery[1] in Singapore's Gillman Barracks, across various

[1] Hereafter also referred to as 'the Gallery'.

modes of interaction – each evoking a different response in the viewer, and fulfilling the purpose of the exhibition differently.

Socio-political Context

Though every individual holds an unshakeable power of contextualisation, an occupational hazard of living in this context is that one often becomes acclimatised to it. An introductory note to *Slow Art*'s wider context must be undertaken. In Singapore, the art scene (like most scenes) is heavily backed and filtered by governmental agencies. Though spaces like Gillman Barracks would be considered more avant-garde owing to the freer rein they are granted compared to national exhibitions, they are still bound by the larger narratives surrounding art written by political, legal and cultural forces.

Following a 2010 national survey that reflected a desire for more 'art-related activities' (Chew, 2017), the Gillman Barracks were established in 2012. The Barracks held a sustained popularity for over half a decade, with the Economic Development Board (EDB), Jurong Town Corporation (JTC) and National Arts Council investing in more eateries in the area in 2014. Despite these measures to increase footfall (and returns), five of its seventeen galleries chose not to renew their lease in 2015.

In 2020, as a result of the Covid-19 pandemic, ever-changing restrictions on group sizes and dining-in negatively impacted the undeniably socially-charged attraction of these exhibitions. However, these factors are merely reflective of the de-prioritization of art in mass culture. What has truly put the Gillman Barracks in crisis is the two galleries that left in early 2020, EDB's lack of funding, and the NTU Centre for Contemporary Art's financial restructuring (Ong, 2020; Toh, 2020). Moreover, the foreign traffic that invested in the galleries by buying the displays has narrowed rapidly.

Taking the aforementioned facts, one would not be amiss to assert that the galleries, including the Sundaram Tagore Gallery, are fuelled by economic motives – more so than usual, whether to remain afloat or cut their losses. Indeed, *Slow Art*'s multi-artist display is, to the knowing critic's eye, a zero-cost venture, using a collection of pieces that the gallery had in stock, not an independently conceptual framework. In other words, the pieces (chosen from previous exhibitions) led to the creation of the narrative, in lieu of the Gallery investing in works to fulfil a narrative. The fact that there was no exhibition guide/catalogue or a named curator only furthers this point.

The website, a democratic and cut-down resource, declares the exhibition as international endeavour in process-driven art, "deliberative, laborious and highly skilled . . . that makes you want to look and linger" (Sundaram Tagore Gallery, 2021). This surface objective as well as the Gallery's economic motives vary in their success across modes of interaction.

The Irony of the Spectator

The desire of the Gallery to make a visitor linger is immediately undermined by the very existence of the spectator interactor. The spectator is not concerned with the painstaking process of art that the exhibition is celebrating to entice a viewer. A seeker of the sublime, they merely pursue sensory stimulation through any medium, thus parse through the Gallery within minutes.

The layout of the Gallery contributes to the dismissal or overlooking of art by the spectator (see Figure 1). The anteroom is tucked into a corner, blocked by a pillar. Its odd and slightly claustrophobic structure gives no satisfaction of symmetry, balance or form. It holds little appeal to the pleasure-driven spectator, and discourages them from the desire to linger.

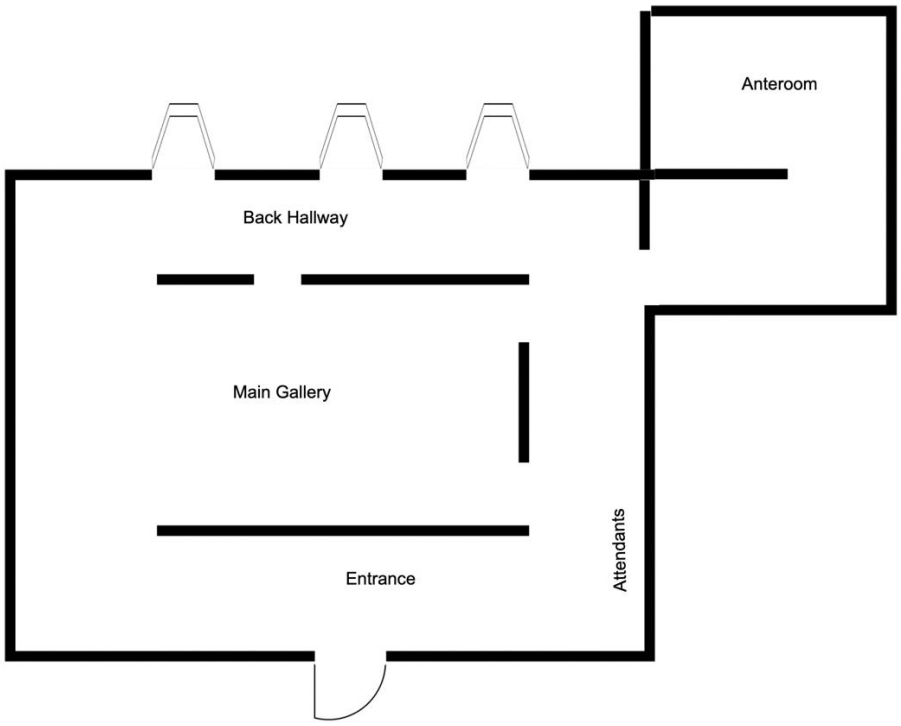


Figure 1. Floor plan of the Sundaram Tagore Gallery, Singapore (Own rendition, 2021).

The back hallway, a tribute to Miya Ando's *72 Seasons* (see Figure 2), may also be neglected by the spectator. Though free from objections of architectural aesthetic, the displays offer little variation among themselves – resulting in a blurring of the pleasure-experience. The two-dimensional (or, more accurately, flat) surfaces feature abstract gradients of colour that use aluminium, resin and urethane to create a sheen. The sensory experience offered is undoubtedly intense, but to the spectator, the individual uniqueness of each work is left unseen – the abstract qualities meld together, rendering an identical experience throughout the hallway, which is quickly felt and discarded. They unconsciously relegate the similarity of the works to a kind of mechanical reproduction as viewed by Benjamin (1969) – a removal of individual auras.



Figure 2. Back hallway of *Slow Art*, featuring select pieces by Miya Ando, 2017 – 2020 (Sundaram Tagore Gallery, 2021).

The main room of the gallery is hence the only remaining space for the spectator to linger, in so far as their attention is held. It contains a variety of works that are relatively larger in size, able to fit on the walls unobstructed by fake ceiling of the anteroom and back hallway (see Figure 2). Thus, “Stop, look and linger” is a lofty aim in the case of the spectator, and reamains partially attained.

Spiritual Technology

In contrast to the spectator, the admirer readily accepts the exhibition’s proposition to look. They appreciate the artistic process celebrated by the displays, as well as identify curatorial intentions through deliberate patterns in the arrangements of the works.

At the entrance, the title of the exhibition is flanked with two of Miya Ando's pieces, marking her work as its focus. At first glance, they seem like watercolour gradients of a sky, but the metallic shine of the greys hints at the viewer an impressions of modernity and industrialization (see Figure 3). A curious paradox that is sustained throughout the gallery emerges – the use of technological breakthroughs to represent natural phenomena, when the two are diametrically opposed.



Figure 3. Ando, M. (2019). (from left to right) *Vermillion 3.3.1*., 91.4 x 91.4 cm; and *Gekkou Moonlight 6*, 115 x 115 cm. Pigment and urethane on aluminium (Sundaram Tagore Gallery, 2021).

A scene from a classical Indian palace, edited to include a tiger, is displayed to the left (see Figure 3). It is separated from other works by a door, so it rests alone in the visual field of

the wall, enhancing linear perspective and creating depth. The glass window on the left allows a generous amount of natural light to fall onto the image, matching and contributing to the lighting of the original image. Using digitally edited photographs with a traditional subject creates a particular dissonance, also seen in Essaydi ahead – the scene seems to resist the medium, distanced through time and technology.

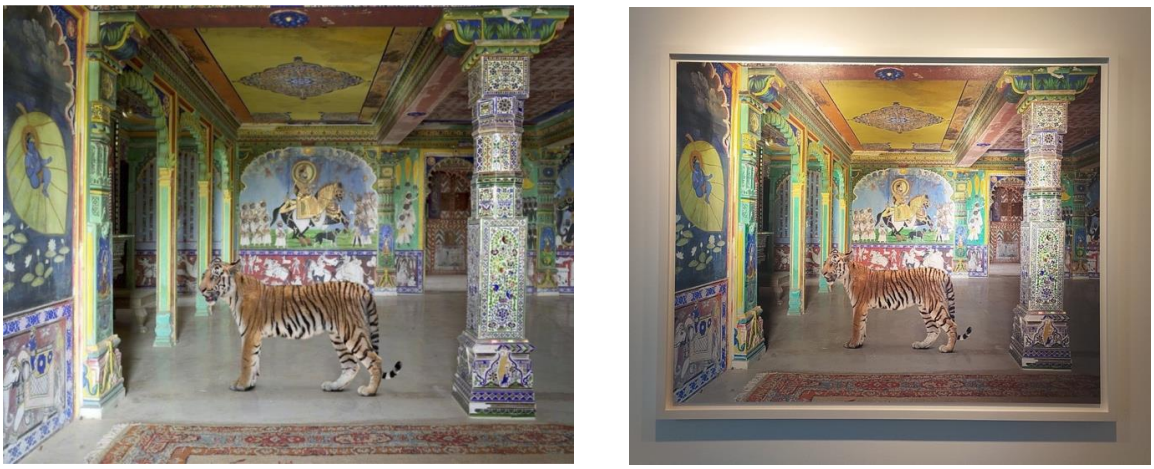


Figure 4. Knorr, K. (2014). *Arjuna's Path, Junha Mahal, Dungarpur*, colour pigment print on Hahnemühle Fine Art Pearl Paper, 122 x 152 cm (Sundaram Tagore Gallery, 2021) side-by-side with the work as presented in the space of the gallery (Own image, 2021).

The main room contains black-and-white artworks alternated with coloured ones (see Figures 5 and 6). This alternating certainly breaks the monotony for the spectator, while visual similarities of the black-and-white works in their linearity draw the attention of the admirer.





Figures 5 and 6. Main room of *Slow Art* in the Sundaram Tagore Gallery (Own images, 2021).

The coloured works are more varied. Essayadi's work elicits realism and qualities of oil painting, with its viscerally traditional harem scene, filled with rich but not-modern textiles opposed to modern minimalist spaces (see Figure 7). It gives the impression of datedness only to be subverted by the edges of the image (and the accompanying plaque), which shows just how technologically driven it is. It subverts the viewer's stereotype of the conservative Gulf country, causing the same dissonance between modernity and tradition.

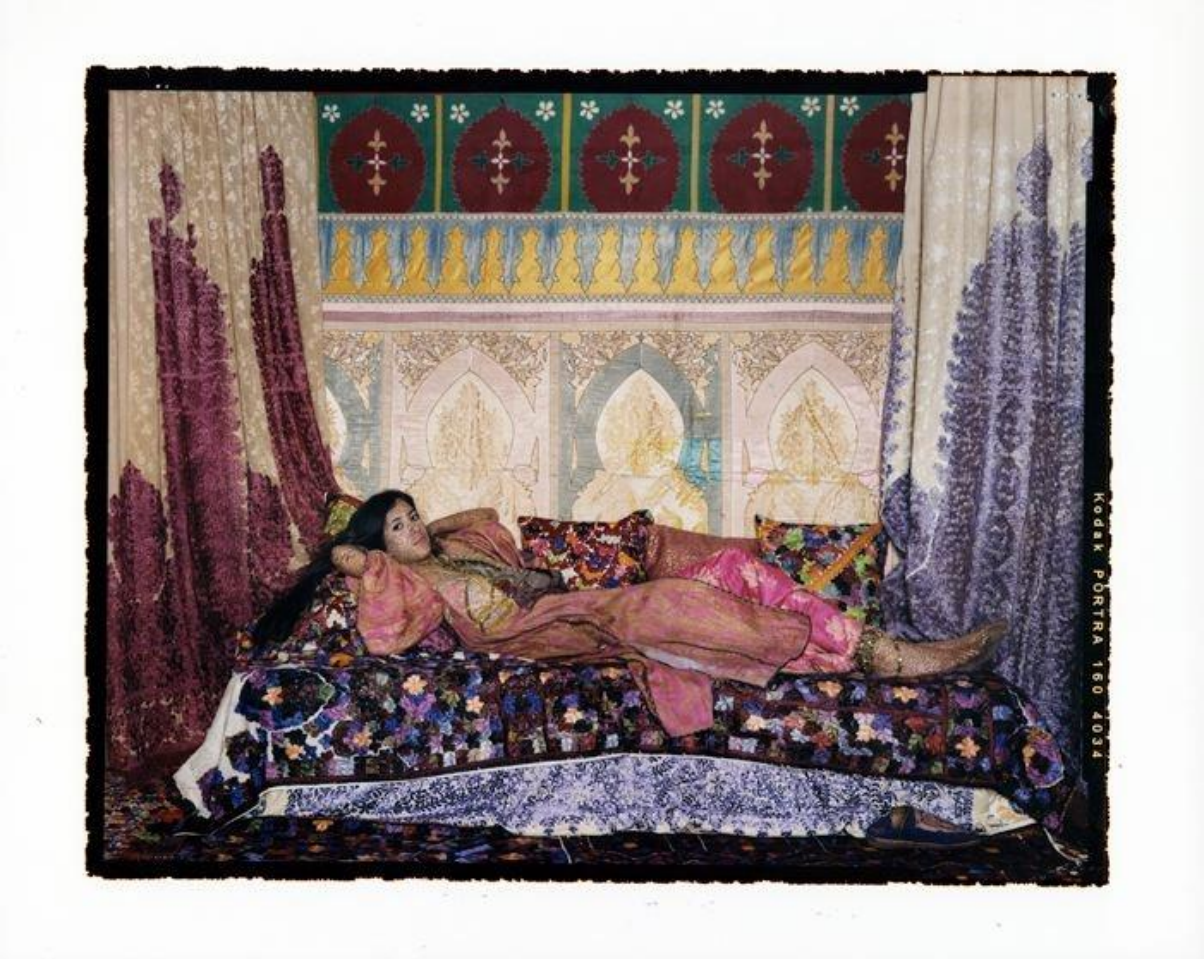


Figure 7. Essaydi, L. (2013) *Harem Revisited #44*. Chromogenic print mounted to aluminium with a UV protective laminate, 121.9 x 152.4 cm (Sundaram Tagore Gallery, 2021).

Chun's *Aggregation 17* stands out, quite literally (see Figure 8). At first glance the colouring seems random, especially considering the angle and size of the work mounted. However, the clear shapes formed by the contrast between the shades of the paper protrusions make the admirer curious, asking them to linger. As we will see in the next section, Chun's works carry deeper exhibition-value.



Figure 8. Chun , K. Y. (2017) *Aggregation 17-FE016*, mixed media with Korean mulberry paper, 184 × 156 cm (Own image, 2021).

Mazal's coloured works frame his monotone display, featuring wave-like shapes (see Figure 9). Juxtaposed with two works of the same material properties (and in one case, dimensions) in tri- and dual-tone, its muteness stands out. Though it has the potential to blend into the white wall, the lighting emphasizes the harsh ridges make it stand out, lending it a texture neither of the other two have.



Figure 9. Mazal, R. (2021). (from left to right) *Full Circle K 7*, *Silence For Sofi 5*, and *Full Circle K 6.* Oil on linen, various dimensions. (Own image, 2021.)

Miya Ando's hallway (see Figure 2) is dreamlike venture of anticipation, hope, wonder and desire, with its lack of harsh colours and misty landscapes. The glass window panes (see Figure 10) interspersed between the dimensionally-identical works are a jarring juxtaposition – Singapore's urban jungle of modernity interfering with the serenity of Ando's work.



Figure 10. Two pieces by Ando (2019), mounted on a wall with a window in-between them. (Own image, 2021).

Senju's romantic *Waterfall* series (see Figure 11) strings the works together – its use of mulberry paper calls out to Chun, and its balanced pattern mimics Mazal, while its more obvious natural subject reduces the abstractness of Ando's work.

Three artists are of particular importance to the critic, owing to their dominance in the exhibtion. Senju's waterfall, Ando's sky, Mazal's waves host a dynamic moment — frozen through the art. The works are laborious constructions, using unconventional and difficult materials. It certainly *slows* the movement of what cannot in reality be paused. This slowing is meditative in creation and effect, attaching a sacredness to the work. The artist guides reinforce this notion, referring to inspirations rooted in the traditional: movement of prayer flags (Mazal; Procter, 2015), the traditional Chinese calendar's 72 seasons and the Buddhist Bodhi tree (Ando; Sundaram Tagore Gallery, 2019), calligraphy and Japanese *nihonga* techniques (Senju; Amy & Baum, 2009).

In linking such modern, technological creations with tradition and spirituality, these works present an intrinsic conflict to the critic. However, to the consumer, this reification of both modern luxury and transcendent nature is its very attraction.

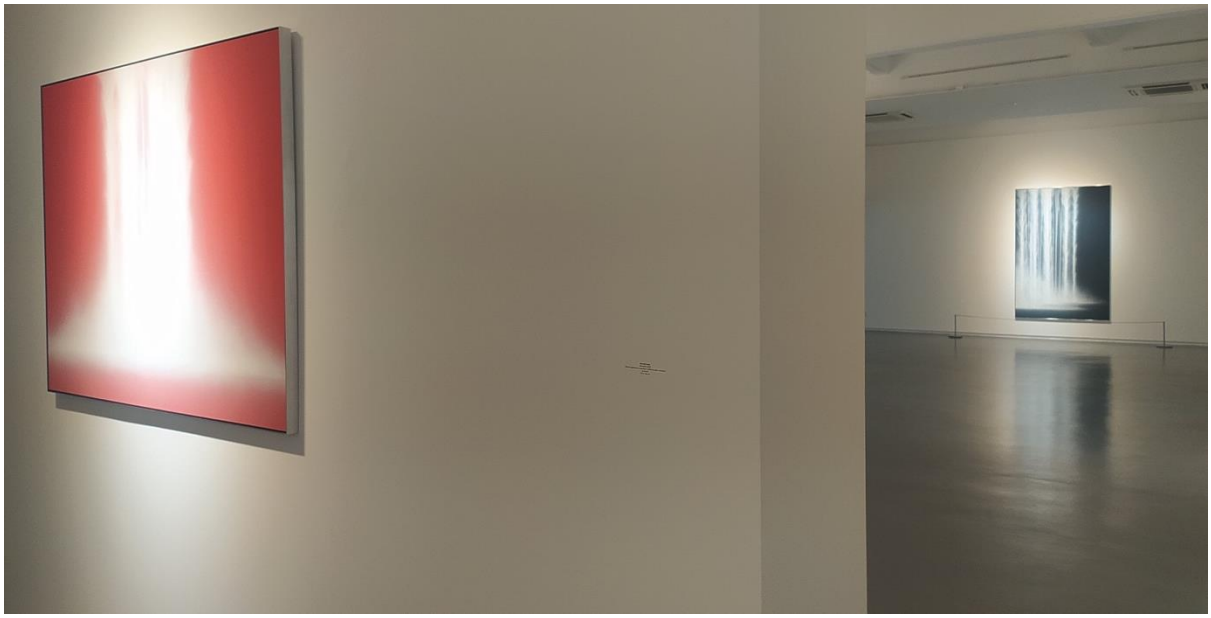


Figure 11. Senju, H. (2020) *Waterfall* and *Waterfall*, natural pigments on Japanese mulberry paper mounted on board, on two separate walls (Own image, 2021).

Call-to-Anteroom

The anteroom, as shown in Figure 1, is a small, outer room separate from the main floor of the gallery. The formula of the empty grid-like space of the gallery (Teh, 2021) is broken here – marred not only by the architectural asymmetry of a pillar, but also by the presence of a non-art object: a table and two chairs (see Figure 12). The space is also relatively well-lit, with the light not only illuminating the artwork as in the rest of the exhibition but also the setup. Another anomaly presents itself in the transparent cover of Chun's (2019) *Aggregation 19 - AP032*, notably the only work so framed.



Figure 12. A glass table and white-leather chair, placed under *Aggregation 19 - AP032* (Chun, 2019) with *Aggregation 19-AU073* (Chun, 2019) set against another wall in the background (Own image, 2021).

There may be practical reasons for this particular set-up: every gallery is also a place of business, with both buyers and suppliers to cater to. It stands to reason that a space must be assigned for the entertainment of these guests. Considering the higher potential of tactility in this case, the special covering for Chun's work can be rationalized. However, this claim is moderately belied by the presence of *Aggregation 19-AU073* in the backdrop – a work that is larger, more varied in its topography and protrudes more – requiring equal, if not greater, safeguarding.

Another possibility might be that the work was recently moved, hence the need for the protective layer – but the fact that the exhibition has been on display for three months gives plenty of buffer time for the move to remove the covering. Though it is entirely possible that the hassle to do so was greater than necessary, one can be reasonably posit that the setup was partially deliberate.

And why would it not be deliberate? A curator has no reason to choose to remove a setup that acts as such an effective call-to-action for the consumer. The setup, from its leather, glass and metal materials to its commercial-like space, impresses upon a viewer a modernist minimalism found in offices. It primes the viewer to think of trade, wealth, and luxury – by both invoking an office-space and emphasizing the exhibition-value of the visual.

Faced with this exact setup, the spectator with buying power becomes a consumer – they are asked to imagine the framed work in their own office or living room, which has familiar furniture as that of the presented setup. The consumer is struck with the desire for possession, to have the abstract concept embodied by the art, as is the want of the spectator-owner (Berger, 1972).

Chun (2019) is a good suspect for this – his work is referred to as celestial, reminiscent of planets and their craters (Becker, 2018). Indeed, if Bezos' recent space launch has done anything, it has cemented to the rich that outer space is the next place to conquer. Chun's use of mulberry paper would resonate specific cultural memories of an East Asian viewer, and impress the trope of Orientalist art to a non-Asian consumer.

The anteroom is thus the tipping point, the part of the exhibition that exists purely for economy, to persuade the consumer to put their money where their eyes are. It is in this part of the gallery where the façade of cult-value in vying for spirituality wears thin – the critic and the consumer are confronted with the art as a product to be bought and sold.

Conclusion

The Gallery is a product of complex socio-politico-economic forces, that presents itself to an even more complex range of interactors. The impossibility of catering to each of these viewers individually and independently culminates in visceral tensions: the ode to slowness

with the sublime, newfound technologies of representation with the physical and metaphysical, and of course, economy and expression.

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